

THE CYPHERPUNK PARADOX

Using Stablecoins to Onboard the World to Bitcoin

Kilian Rausch

CEO & Co-Founder · Boltz

BCC8333 · 2026

BARCELONA CYPHERS CONFERENCE

01

PART ONE

The cypherpunk question we
keep ducking.

A CYPHERPUNK'S MANIFESTO · 1993

//

Cypherpunks
write code.

— Eric Hughes

//

Privacy is the power
to **selectively** reveal
oneself to the world.

The line that matters thirty-three years later

THE CYPHERPUNK WIN · 17 YEARS LIVE

Bitcoin is the
cypherpunk code
that **actually shipped.**

Seventeen years. A new block every ten minutes. No trusted third party. We won...?

Code nobody uses
is just code.

The same way a Bitcoin node you're running but never connect to your wallet
is just... a curiosity.

Money nobody uses
is just a
cyphepunk dream.

Hughes didn't write a manifesto so we'd build the soundest but largely unspendable money in history.

THE DAILY-LIFE GAP · 17 YEARS IN

We won the protocol.
We did not win **daily life**.

LIGHTNING NETWORK · NOV 2025

\$1.17B/mo

Best month on record. **5.2M payments**, avg \$223 — mostly exchange flow, not coffee.

River · Sam Wouters, Feb 2026

THE DAILY-LIFE GAP · 17 YEARS IN

We won the protocol.
We did not win **daily life**.

LIGHTNING NETWORK · NOV 2025

\$1.17B/mo

Best month on record. 5.2M payments, avg \$223 —
mostly exchange flow, not coffee.

River · Sam Wouters, Feb 2026

VISA + MASTERCARD · MONTHLY

\$2.28T/mo

\$176.9B monthly growth · 7–9% YoY.

Visa & Mastercard FY2025 reports

vs.

02

PART TWO

**Meanwhile, the dollar got an
API.**

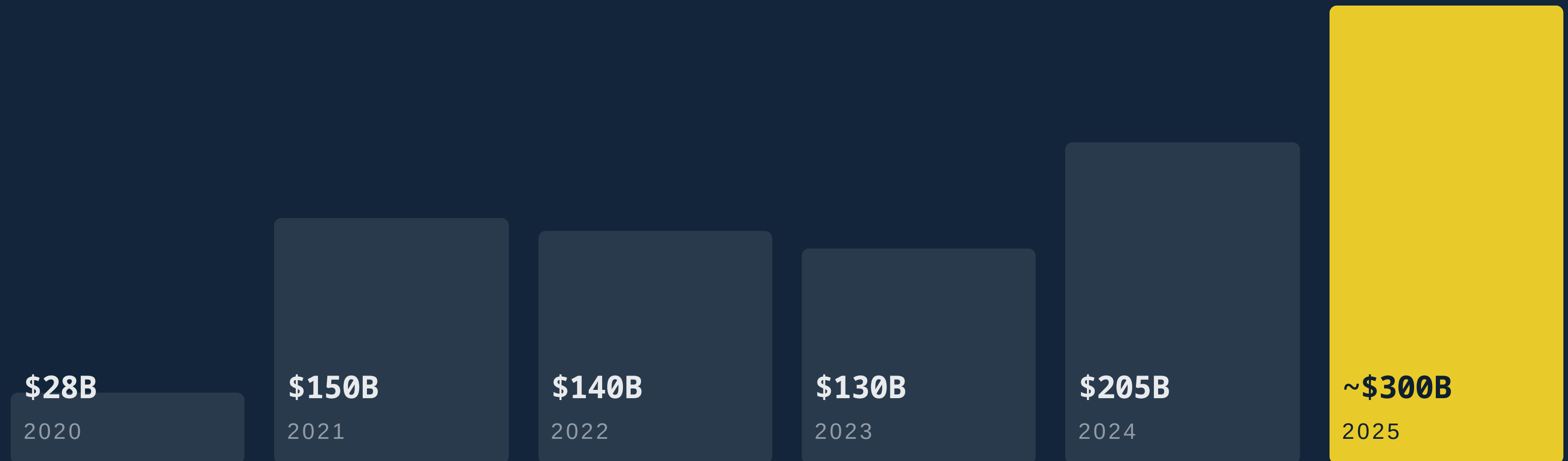
CALLING IT WHAT IT IS

Stablecoins are Fiat. Full stop.

A wrapped dollar IOU. Private issuer. Compliant (Read: "freezable").

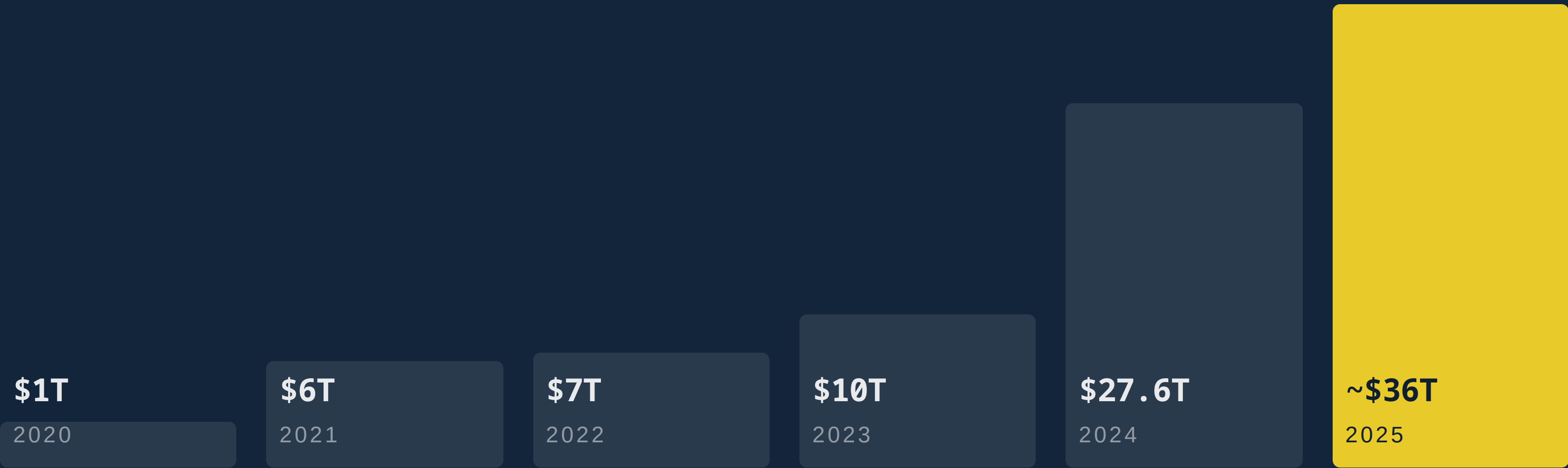
STABLECOIN SUPPLY · 2020 → 2026

From \$5B to nearly \$300B, while we weren't paying attention.



In 2025 USDT & USDC accounted for ≈ 80% of supply

From \$1T to \$36T while we argued cov op codes and spam.



Adjusted, excl. bot wash

Did you pay attention? The biggest payment rail in 2025 is the one we try not to touch.

~\$14B

LIGHTNING

~\$18T

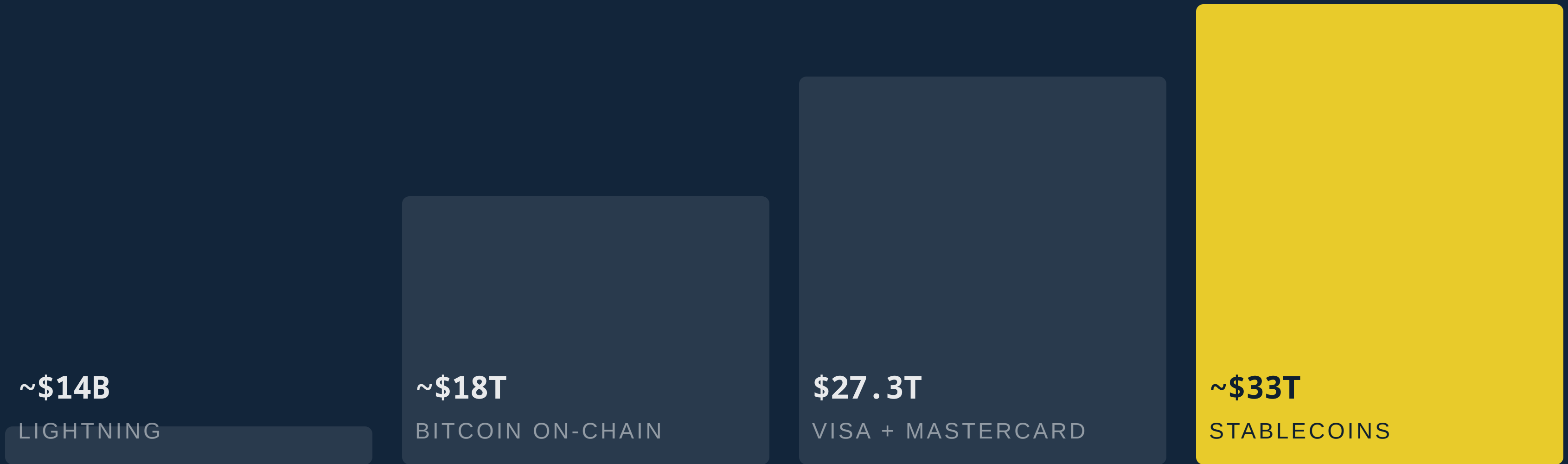
BITCOIN ON-CHAIN

\$27.3T

VISA + MASTERCARD

~\$33T

STABLECOINS



Washington just gave dollar tokens a **home**.

2025 · ENACTED

GENIUS Act

Federal framework for **payment stablecoins**.

Issuer licensing. 1:1 reserves in cash & T-bills. Disclosure rules. Stablecoins are now first-class US payment instruments.

2025 · ENACTED

CLARITY Act

SEC vs. CFTC, finally **settled**.

Draws the line between securities and digital commodities. Issuers, exchanges and DeFi finally know which agency owns which token.

TETHER'S RESPONSE

USA[₮]

A US-domiciled stablecoin **built for GENIUS**.

Launched Jan 2026. Issued by Anchorage Digital Bank, reserves at Cantor Fitzgerald. Tether's move to onshore its US business — and take Circle on home turf.

Two pieces of legislation. One purpose: pull dollar-based stablecoins under a federal rulebook.

THE HONEST DISCLOSURE

Regulated & Freezable. **By**
design.

THE PIVOT · WHY THIS MATTERS FOR US

THIS IS THE PART NOBODY TALKS ABOUT

...they settle on rails we can natively
interact with.



USDC

Circle · US

~\$61B supply



EURC

Circle · Euro

MiCA-compliant · EU



USDT

Tether · global

~\$173B supply



USAT 

Tether · US-domiciled

Launched Jan 2026 ·
GENIUS-compliant

Stablecoins are going **local**.

EXHIBIT A · 25 MAY 2026



GEL₹



Georgian Lari stablecoin

Issued by Tether, jointly developed with the Government of Georgia.

National-currency stablecoins now have government partners.

\$0 → \$400M /MO

BRLA (Brazilian-Real stablecoin) monthly transfer volume from early 2023 to early 2026.

50% → 75% DOMESTIC

Share of stablecoin payments that stay inside one country from 2024 to 2026. Less cross-border remittance, more everyday local settlement.

The agentic web is starting to emerge. And it pays for itself. **Just not in sats.**

L402 · LIGHTNING · 2020

690 endpoints

30 providers. Lightning leaves no chain footprint. The integration count after 6 years is the signal.

402index.io · 27 May 2026

VS.

X402 · COINBASE · MAY 2025

44.6k endpoints

604 providers. 65× L402 in 12 months.

402index.io · 27 May 2026

Same HTTP 402 spec. Lightning is technically the best at micropayments but the agents went elsewhere.

03

PART THREE

How do we make stablecoins work **for** Bitcoin?

THE MERCHANT SIDE

Merchants don't want Bitcoin. They want **dollars**.

THE MERCHANT ASK

**Predictable accounting.
Instant settlement. No FX
risk.**

Bitcoin volatility kills the argument. Holding Bitcoin means headache and perceived "risk". Asking a merchant to take Bitcoin loses the sale.

THE PRAGMATIC MOVE

**Give them the dollar. Settle
Bitcoin behind the scenes.**

The merchant never sees or touches Bitcoin. The customer never holds stablecoins. Everyone gets what they came for.

THE USER SIDE

Bitcoiners don't want dollars. They want to **spend** their Bitcoin.

USE CASES · LIVE TODAY

Top up a crypto debit card.
Deposit into your neobank.
Pay an online merchant.

Without leaving your Bitcoin wallet. Without giving up custody. Without an account. Sats ↔ stable, on demand.

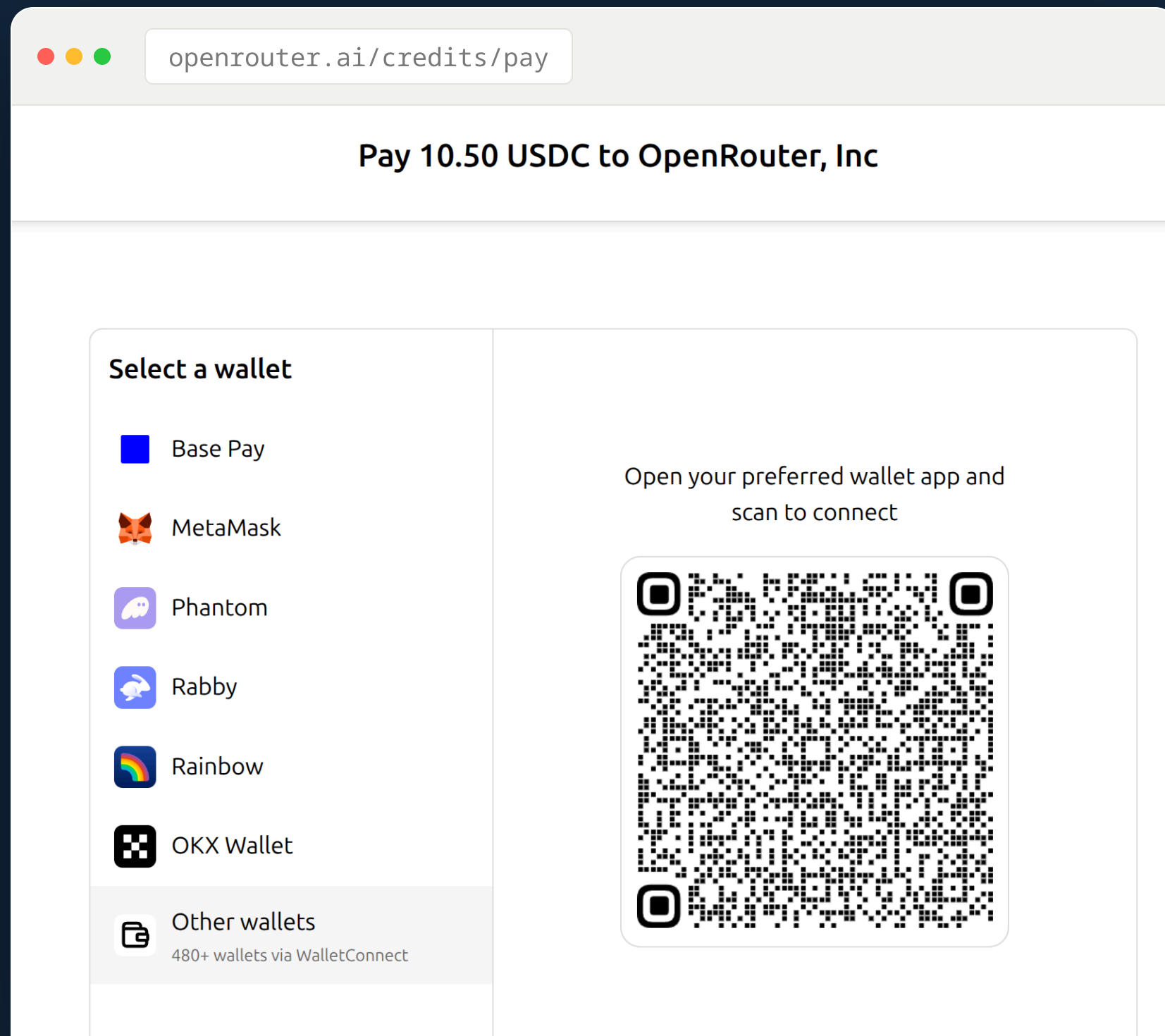
THE HUGHES TEST

Selectively reveal yourself to the dollar system, only when you have to.

Swap to stablecoins, the new fiat, in the moment when you need to. Keep your privacy. The 1993 manifesto approves.

A REAL USDC CHECKOUT · TODAY

A typical merchant checkout. It only takes **USDC**.



WHAT THIS CHECKOUT ASKS FOR

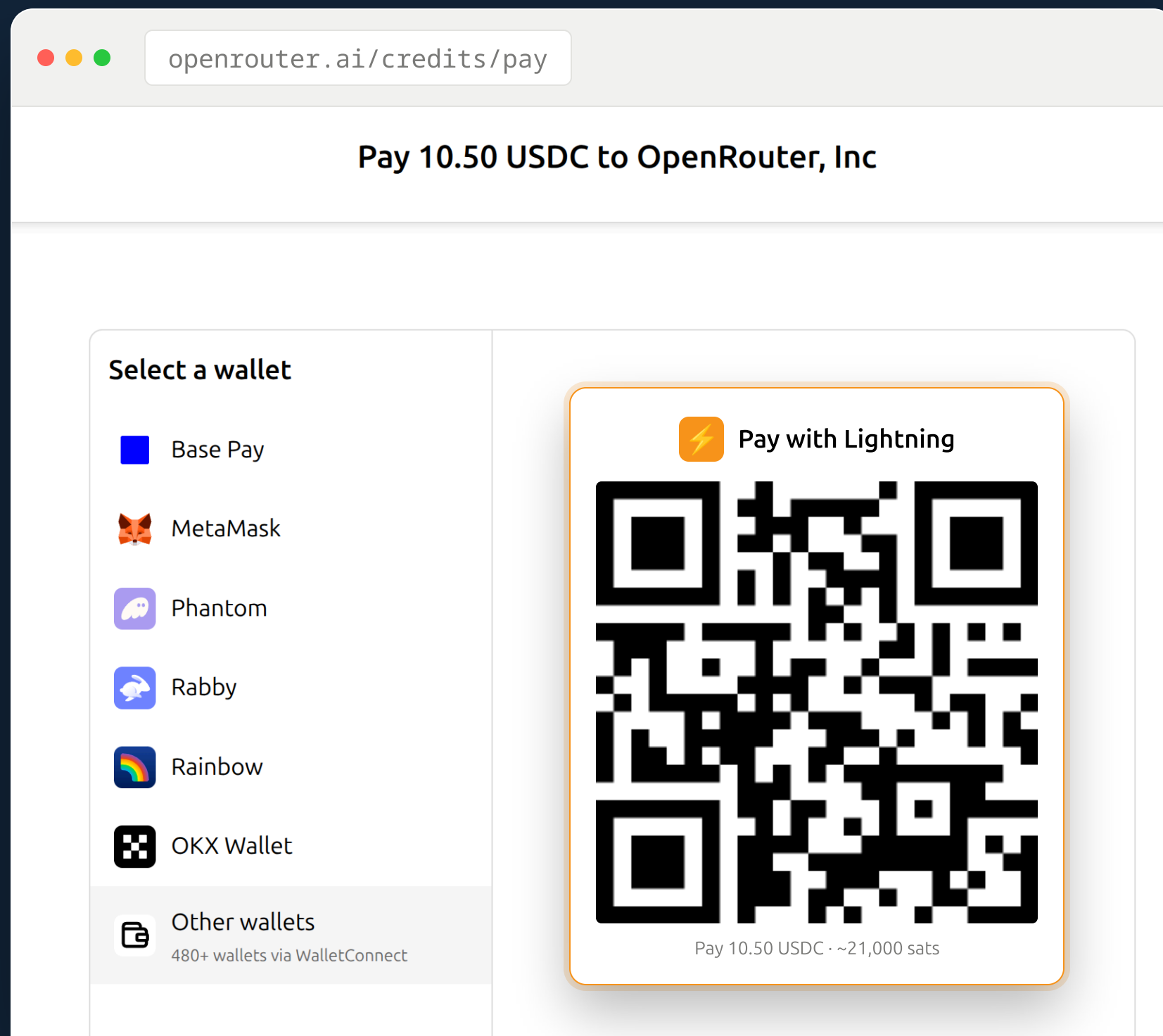
A **USDC** balance.
On the right chain.
In a wallet they recognize.

MetaMask, Phantom, Rabby, OKX, WalletConnect — all things many Bitcoiners are not very familiar with.

No Lightning. No Bitcoin. No sats.

THE MOVE · MAKE BITCOIN COMPATIBLE WITH ANY USDC CHECKOUT

Slap Lightning on top. Same merchant. Same **USDC**.



SAME CHECKOUT. LIGHTNING ADDED.

You paid **sats**.
Merchant settles in USDC.

Drop Lightning into any USDC or USDT checkout. Without the merchant touching Bitcoin, and without Bitcoiners touching USDC.
And most importantly: Without adding trust assumptions.

04

PART FOUR

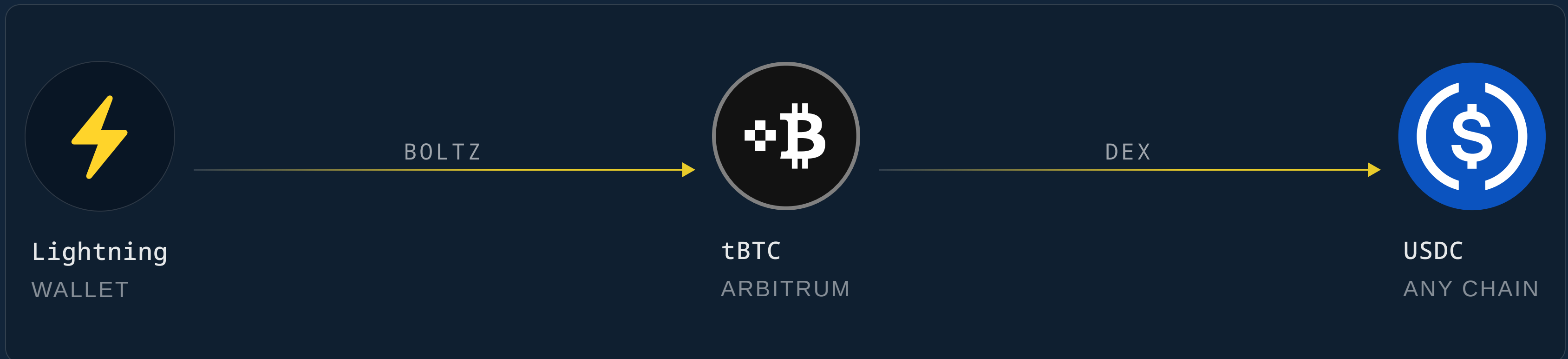
In **cryptography** we trust. No added trust assumptions.

One signature. One transaction. **Atomic.**

Either everything settles, or nothing happened. You never give up control over your funds and there is no room for a middleman to rug.



Lightning → tBTC → USDC. In **one** transaction.



claim

Boltz releases tBTC against your Lightning preimage.

execute

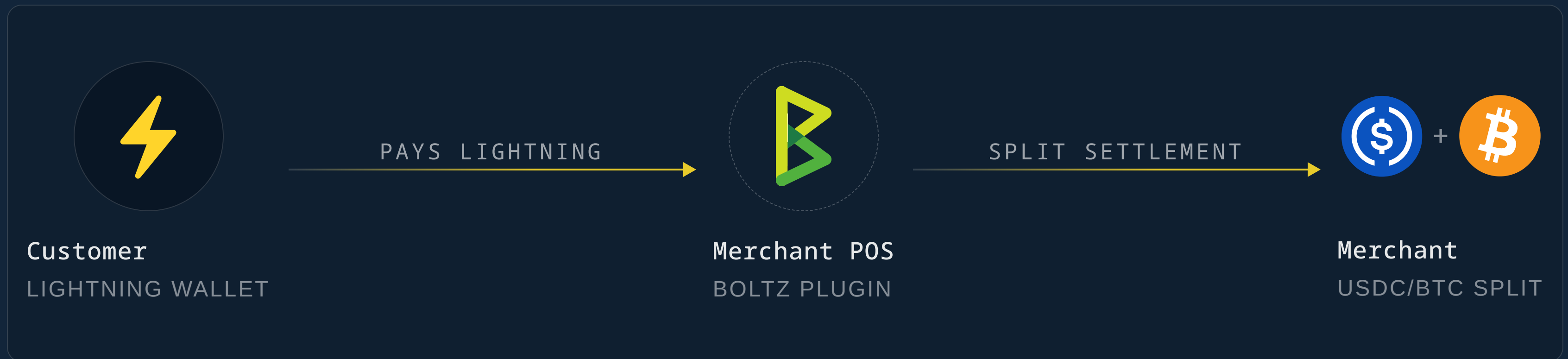
Router swaps tBTC → USDC on a DEX. Slippage-protected.

sweep

USDC lands in your wallet — Base, Ethereum, Arbitrum, Solana, Polygon, any CCTP chain.

All three steps run in one transaction. If any leg fails, the whole thing reverts.

Accept Lightning. Settle in **dollars**. Or split BTC and USDC.



WHAT IS **NOT** REQUIRED

It should feel like Bitcoin. So it does.

// **NO**

ETH.

Gas abstraction handles gas on your behalf.
You never hold an ETH or other gas balance.

// **NO**

KYC.

No documents. No selfie. Nobody needs to
know your name.

// **NO**

Accounts.

No email. No password. No Sign-Up.

05

PART FIVE

The world I want to live in.

THE CONFRONTATION

Pragmatism over purity.
Adoption is the war.

THE WORLD WE WANT

Cyberpunks build bridges.

LIVE IN PRODUCTION

boltz.exchange

Find me at the BBQ tomorrow if you're a merchant, wallet builder, or you just want to argue ;) But let's onboard the next billion!

